

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 10 Assignment — Stakeholder Management & Influence

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

QA at Northstar is blamed for slow releases because of the five-day regression, yet it is pulled into squads too late to prevent the defects that make regression necessary. You need to change that narrative with the people who matter: Priya, who wants risk and delivery outcomes; Tom, who pushes on dates but responds to clearly shown residual risk; Marcus, who is unconvinced QA adds value; and a CTO who wants "faster, safer releases". You have been asked to deliver a simulated executive quality briefing.

What you'll demonstrate

- Map stakeholders and tailor the message to each
- Reframe QA from a bottleneck to a risk-and-delivery partner
- Communicate quality status to executives clearly and credibly
- Prepare for the difficult conversations, especially with a sceptic

What to submit

- An Executive Quality Briefing (the simulated briefing document)
- A completed Stakeholder Map for the named Northstar stakeholders
- A Difficult Conversation Planner for the conversation with Marcus
- An Executive Quality Update and a Release Risk Communication example

Step-by-step

1. Build the Stakeholder Map, capturing each person's priorities, influence and current view of QA
2. Prepare the Executive Quality Briefing pitched to how Priya and the CTO actually consume information
3. Draft an Executive Quality Update that reframes the regression narrative around when QA is engaged
4. Use the Difficult Conversation Planner to prepare for Marcus's scepticism without becoming defensive
5. Show how you would communicate a live release risk to the business using the communication template

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX assembling the briefing, the stakeholder map and the conversation plans.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- Messages genuinely tailored to each stakeholder's priorities
- QA reframed as a delivery partner, evidenced not merely asserted
- An executive briefing that speaks in risk and outcomes, not test activity
- A credible, non-defensive plan for winning over a sceptic like Marcus
- Clarity a time-poor executive would thank you for

Templates & resources to use

- Stakeholder Map — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Difficult Conversation Planner — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Executive Quality Update — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Release Risk Communication Template — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Influence is earned in the language of the listener. Talk to Priya about delivery risk and to Tom about residual risk on the date he cares about — and never walk into the room with Marcus without having planned the conversation first.